

Clinically recommended Arthritis Exercises

Discover NHS-recommended exercises for arthritis. UK physiotherapist-approved low-impact workouts to ease joint pain.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

NHS-Recommended Exercises for Arthritis



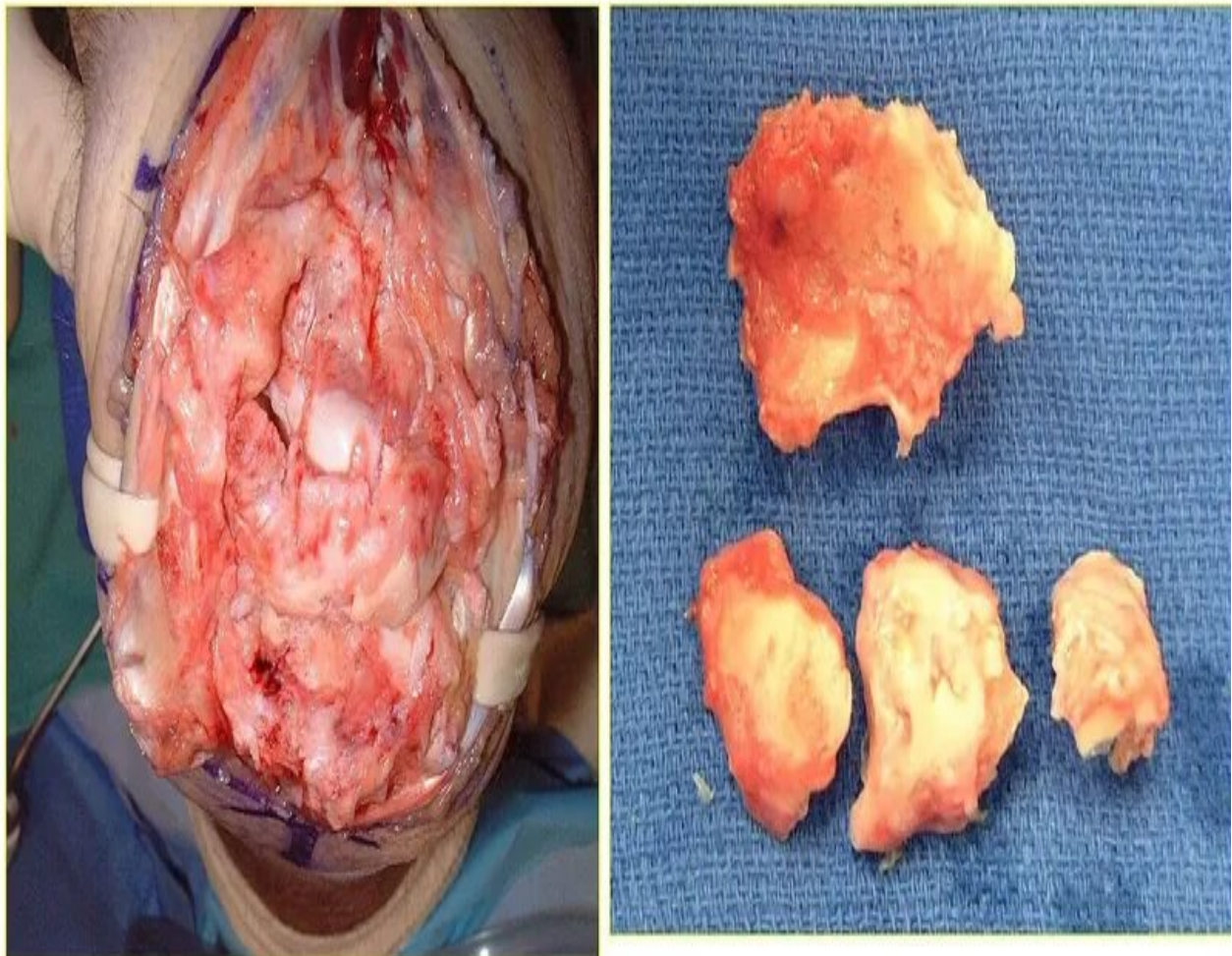
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The NHS and NICE guidelines strongly recommend exercise as a core treatment for arthritis. Regular physical activity is as effective as painkillers for many patients — with none of the side effects.

What NICE Recommends

The National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE) recommends: - **Aerobic exercise** — at least 150 minutes of moderate activity per week - **Strengthening exercises** — targeting muscles around affected joints, at least twice weekly - **Flexibility work** — daily stretching and range-of-motion exercises

Top NHS-Approved Exercises



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Walking The simplest and most accessible exercise. Start with 10 minutes and build up gradually. - **Goal:** 30 minutes, 5 days per week - **Benefits:** Improves cardiovascular health, supports weight management

Swimming & Aqua Aerobics Water supports your body weight, making movement easier and less painful. - **Pool temperature:** Aim for 28–32°C for comfort - **Benefits:** Full-body workout with minimal joint impact

Cycling Stationary or outdoor cycling strengthens leg muscles without high joint impact. - **Start:** 10 minutes at low resistance - **Benefits:** Builds quad and hamstring strength

Tai Chi NICE specifically recommends tai chi for older adults with OA. - **Frequency:** 1–2 classes per week - **Benefits:** Improves balance, flexibility, and pain management



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Strength Training Light resistance work builds the muscles that protect joints. - **Start:** Bodyweight exercises (wall push-ups, chair squats) - **Progress:** Add resistance bands, then light weights

The 24-Hour Rule

If your joints are more painful or swollen 24 hours after exercising, you overdid it. Reduce intensity next time but do not stop entirely — rest is rarely the answer.

Where to Get Help

- **NHS Physiotherapy** — ask your GP for a referral
- **NHS Fitness Studio** — many leisure centres offer arthritis-specific classes
- **Versus Arthritis** — free exercise guides and videos
- **Living With Arthritis** — our free virtual physiotherapy programme

Reviewed by Claire Watson, MCSP, NHS Senior Physiotherapist

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about clinically recommended arthritis exercises?

Short answer: To manage arthritis, the NHS recommends at least 150 minutes of moderate aerobic exercise weekly, strengthening exercises targeting affected joints at least twice a week, and daily flexibility work. Examples include walking, swimming, cycling, Tai Chi, and light strength training. If joints are more painful 24 hours after exercise, reduce intensity, but do not stop exercising.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk